

Gallery Host Plus (GH+) Proposal

An Equity-Centered Model for Growth, Collaboration, and Cultural Stewardship at The Newark Museum of Art

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I. Executive Summary

Gallery Hosts are essential to The Newark Museum of Art's daily operations and guest experience. They protect art, offer guidance, and hold presence across all public galleries. This proposal outlines Gallery Host Plus (GH+), an advancement framework that honors the care and energy Gallery Hosts bring by creating structured cross-departmental learning pathways, phased compensation growth, and deeper integration into the museum's creative and operational life.

GH+ builds on what's already working: the consistency and adaptability of Gallery Hosts like Angel Suero, the museum's paid internship model, and a vision for sustainable cultural labor. The pilot begins in Summer 2025 and can scale into a long-term Frontline Fellowship model in the years ahead.

II. Institutional Context

The Newark Museum of Art maintains an approximately \$16.5 million annual operating budget. With visitor-generated revenue covering only around \$200k–\$300k per year, the institution is powered by grants, philanthropy, and mission-aligned partnerships.

Despite their visibility and consistency, Gallery Hosts currently earn \$15.49–\$15.91/hour, depending on hire date. Meanwhile, NMOA's internship program pays \$18/hour, offering skill-building and departmental access. GH+ addresses this gap by enabling hosts to evolve inside their role—offering tiered growth without requiring them to “apply up” or leave.

III. What is GH+?

Empowered from the Gallery Outward:

GH+ envisions Gallery Hosts not only as protectors of the collection but as emerging practitioners—mini-curators, registrars-in-training, storytellers, and AV apprentices. By making departmental learning visible and accessible, GH+ transforms routine coverage into a platform for career exploration and creative agency. Hosts don't step outside their roles to grow—they expand their impact from within them.

Gallery Host Plus (GH+) is a two-part system:

1. **Core Gallery Host (GH)**

- **Responsibilities:** Gallery coverage, art protection, guest support
- **Schedule:** During all museum open hours
- **Wage:** \$15.49–\$15.91/hr

2. **GH+ (Growth Track)**

- **Entry:** Is based on tenure or application
- **Role:** Hosts remain on the floor but gain time and support to contribute to:
 - Collections tasks
 - Public Programs support
 - Philanthropy storytelling
 - AV setup
 - Interpretation and gallery content
 - Shadowing opportunities across departments
- **Time Allocation:** Time set aside during relief shifts, low-traffic hours, or structured check-ins

IV. Case Example: Angel Suero

- **Tenure:** Since October 2021
- **Gallery Affinity:** 3rd Floor – Tibetan Buddhist Altar
- **Personal Practice:** Meditation, spiritual alignment
- **Schedule Insight:** On Saturday, April 5th, Angel works a full shift with a relief hour from 11:30 a.m. to 12:30 p.m.

Angel’s consistency and spiritual approach make him an ideal candidate for GH+. His presence in the Tibetan Altar gallery brings calm, cultural attentiveness, and care. During his relief time or quieter hours, he could contribute to:

- **Collections:** garment tagging or data input
- **Public Programs:** preparing space or assisting with sound checks
- **Interpretation:** sharing reflections to support new labels or prompts
- **Philanthropy:** contributing to visitor narrative language in grant proposals

V. Alignment with Internship Model

Role	Wage	Features
Intern	\$18/hr	Structured, 10–12 weeks, cross-department exposure
Gallery Host	\$15.49–\$15.91/hr	Operational floor work, guest experience
GH+ (proposed)	Tiered	Gallery-based role +

		supported cross-training
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GH+ closes the equity gap between interns and existing staff while maximizing host consistency and presence.

VI. Livable Wage Trajectory (Newark)

Track	Hourly Wage	Path
Base Gallery Host	\$15.49–\$15.91/hr	Entry-level, current staffing
GH+ Tier 1 (2+ yrs or participation)	\$18/hr	Matches internship rate
GH+ Tier 2 (Cross-trained support)	\$20/hr	Consistent contribution to a department
GH+ Tier 3 (Specialization/Mentorship)	\$22–24/hr	Peer training, public-facing storytelling

Note: See Appendix A for Newark cost of living benchmarks.

VII. GH+ Pilot Program (Summer–Fall 2025)

- **Title:** GH+ Pathways: Gallery Leadership from Within
- **Timeline:** May–August 2025 (Approx. 16 weeks)
- **Participants:** 3–5 Gallery Hosts
- **Departments Involved:** Curatorial, Collections, AV, Development, Public Programs

Core Components

- Maintain 28–32 hr/week schedules
- Build-in 1–2 hrs/wk for reflection, writing, or project shadowing
- Connect with departmental mentors
- Co-design updated uniforms through Project Fit
- Contribute to gallery storytelling, audio prompts, or surveys
- Utilize new equipment options (see Appendix C)

Example Tracks Overview

Focus Area	Host Contribution
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Collections	Assist with rehousing, tagging, data entry (via TMS)
Public Programs	Support set-up, greet attendees, document visitor flow
Interpretation	Share personal insights, help draft prompts
AV Support	Mic checks, minor troubleshooting, visitor sound setup
Philanthropy	Capture frontline perspectives for impact storytelling

GH+ Sample Track Detail (Fictional Example)

- **Track Focus:** AV Support & Public Programs
- **Gallery Affinity:** 1st Floor – Special Exhibitions Gallery
- **Goals:**
 - Develop foundational understanding of AV tools used in museum events and exhibitions
 - Build experience assisting in setup and breakdown for live programs
 - Strengthen public presence and communication during guest-facing events
- **Key Components:**
 - 1.5 hrs/week of focused time on Fridays during prep hours for evening events
 - Shadowing with Gabriel Serrano (AV Coordinator) and Maegan Douglas (Director, Public Programs)
 - Assist in AV checks, audience mic prep, and ambient sound adjustment
- **Deliverables by August 2025:**
 - Support three major evening programs from setup to closeout
 - Complete a checklist guide for future Gallery Hosts joining AV-related support
 - Record an audio reflection for internal training or interpretive testing

VIII. Internal Implementation Plan: Verified Staff Roles

To ensure success, the GH+ pilot must be championed and supported by key team members across the Museum:

Core Leads

- Gallery Host (Pilot Case)
- Jonathan Dix – Manager, Visitor Experience
- Yasin Bennane – Senior Manager, Inclusion and Belonging
- Giselle Holloway – Director, Membership & Visitor Experience

Finance & Executive

- Linda C. Harrison – Director and CEO
- Sayaka Araki – Chief Financial Officer
- Mary Dowd – Chief of Staff
- Marsha Bonner – Deputy Director, People, Culture

Departmental Tracks

- Catherine Evans – Deputy Director, Collections
- Maegan Douglas – Director, Public Programs
- Gabriel Serrano – Coordinator, Audio-Visual
- Jessica Nuñez – Director, Education
- Peter T. Wilderotter – Deputy Director, Philanthropy & External Relations
- Kate Place Astle – Director, Grants and Funds

Operational & Facilities Support

- David May – Senior Director, Facilities Operations
- Peter Bumanlag – Director, Security
- Shawn Slappy – Director, Building Services

Peer Support (Hosts)

- Angelaina Rajram – Senior Gallery Host
- Emily Noonan – Senior Gallery Host
- Brunylda Rosa, Idalis Rodriguez – Gallery Hosts (GH+ Pilot Candidates)

This structure ensures that GH+ is both grounded in the Museum's staffing reality and scaffolded with leadership accountability and cross-departmental buy-in.

IX. Scheduling Fit

Using April 5th's Schedule as a model, GH+ can activate during:

- Relief blocks (e.g., Angel's 11:30–12:30)
- Low-traffic mornings or post-event resets
- Wednesdays/Fridays, which often have lighter attendance

X. Health & Sustainability: Occupational Considerations

To make GH+ not only inspiring but sustainable, this proposal includes a new focus on health and equipment.

See **Appendix B: Occupational Health Considerations for Gallery Hosts**, which addresses:

- Physical strain: prolonged standing, footwear, ergonomic mats
- Visual strain: managing eye fatigue in low-light galleries

- Noise exposure: protections during events (earplugs, rotation)
- Mental health: combating monotony, supporting mindfulness, fostering connection
- Equipment upgrades: See Appendix C for AI access, ear protection, and optional self-defense training

All wellness-related equipment and training will be optional, trauma-informed, and aligned with the museum's existing guest engagement and safety policies.

XI. Long-Term Vision: From GH+ to Fellowship

GH+ lays the groundwork for a salaried **Frontline Fellowship**—a cohort-based, project-embedded program for Gallery Hosts evolving into full-time cultural workers.

Fellowship Features

- \$50–55k salary + benefits
- Rotations across Collections, Public Engagement, and Exhibitions
- Host one gallery-based project (audio tour, blog, event, etc.)
- Public presentation or report
- 1 shift/week in gallery as an anchor to public space

XII. Strategic Institutional Benefits

Area	GH+ Value
Staff Retention	Grows from within; combats turnover
Equity Practice	Offers paid pathways beyond unpaid labor or unpaid access
Visitor Experience	Builds stronger interpretation and spatial care
Development & Storytelling	Hosts provide real stories for grant narratives
Organizational Culture	Increases joy, collaboration, and belonging institutionally
DEIA Alignment	Directly supports DEIA goals via equitable internal career pathways

- **Sample quote:** "Having a GH+ team member shadow our AV setup would ease our load significantly during public events." — *Events Coordinator*
- **Sample quote:** "I'd love to mentor a host who's interested in storytelling for the Ballantine House." — *Curator, Decorative Arts*

XIII. Evaluation Metrics for GH+ Pilot

To assess success and scalability:

- Host retention at 6-month and 12-month benchmarks
- Number of shadowing and cross-training hours completed
- Visitor satisfaction (pre/post GH+ storytelling implementation)
- Departmental satisfaction survey (mentors and host departments)
- Percentage of GH+ participants who transition to internships or fellowships

XIV. Future Vision Timeline

GH+ opens the door to long-term, cross-functional careers inside the museum. Participation in this pathway is fully optional and personalized—designed to offer Gallery Hosts the opportunity to grow without pressure or obligation. For those who choose to pursue it, the GH+ timeline below outlines a suggested 10–12 year journey from entry-level to professional specialization.

Years	Title/Role	Description
Years 1–1.5	Gallery Host (GH)	Entry-level role focused on gallery coverage and visitor experience
Years 1.5–3	GH+ Tier 1	Cross-departmental exposure; stipend or increased hourly rate
Years 3–4.5	GH+ Tier 2	Specialized contributions (e.g. AV support, collections tagging)
Years 4.5–6	GH+ Tier 3	Peer mentorship, interpretation feedback, audio storytelling
Years 6–8	Frontline Fellow	Salaried cohort-based track with rotating departmental projects
Years 8+	Program Associate / Assistant Curator / Asst. Registrar	Transition to full-time role based on skills and departmental fit

This vision illustrates that Gallery Hosts are not a static position, but a developmental pipeline for Newark-based cultural workers—one that centers choice, creativity, and lived experience as part of museum practice.

XV. Implementation Timeline

Assuming the GH+ concept is newly introduced to the museum, this timeline outlines a conservative and realistic 2-year rollout to ensure departmental buy-in, budget stability, and measurable impact.

Phase 1: Planning & Internal Awareness (April–June 2025)

- Circulate GH+ proposal to department heads and executive leadership
- Conduct 1:1 info sessions with Gallery Hosts, VEX team, and pilot mentors
- Secure feedback from departments involved in pilot (Collections, AV, Public Programs, Development)
- Begin early scheduling scenarios with Visitor Experience
- *Inhibitors:* End-of-fiscal-year timing, lack of awareness, competing projects

Phase 2: Pilot Launch & Initial Testing (July–September 2025)

- Activate 3–5 GH+ tracks using relief or low-traffic time
- Implement AV, interpretation, and collections collaborations
- Begin evaluation (reflections, surveys, shift log data)
- *Inhibitors:* AV & Programs are busiest in summer; limited time for deep mentorship

Phase 3: Data Review & Proposal Scaling (October–December 2025)

- Present pilot findings to CFO, HR, and DEAI teams
- Co-author next phase budget proposal with Grants & Development
- Identify external funding opportunities (city partnerships, arts funders)

Phase 4: GH+ Institutionalization (January–June 2026)

- Expand to 8–10 hosts with rotating assignments
- Integrate GH+ goals into annual VEX evaluations
- Launch Project Fit phase II (uniform prototyping)

Phase 5: Frontline Fellowship Foundation (July 2026–Early 2027)

- Design fellowship pilot plan with sample rotations and outcomes
- Align staffing with projected hiring needs across departments
- Prep grant/foundation materials for long-term fellow funding

By mid-2027, GH+ can be an embedded cultural workforce pipeline tied to Newark equity goals and museum-wide sustainability metrics.

XVI. Conclusion

GH+ doesn't reinvent—it evolves.

This proposal activates possibility inside the walls of the museum, where the staff

already greet, protect, and interpret every single day. It creates room for Gallery Hosts to deepen, specialize, and grow—not as a departure from their role, but as an expression of it. Furthermore, it empowers hosts to bring their valuable Newark community perspectives and lived experiences into the heart of the museum's work.

By investing in equity from the ground floor, GH+ helps The Newark Museum of Art become not just a home for collections, but for careers.

GH+ builds frontline power by honoring Newark’s cultural knowledge, lived experience, and spiritual insight—not as add-ons, but as essential museum content.

Appendices

- **Appendix A:** Newark Livable Wage Tiers
- **Appendix B:** Occupational Health Considerations for Gallery Hosts
- **Appendix C:** Equipment Recommendations for Gallery Hosts
- **Appendix D:** Pilot Program Budget Outline (Estimated)
- **Appendix E:** Risk Assessment and Mitigation Strategies

Appendix A: Newark Livable Wage Tiers

To ensure GH+ wage tiers reflect local economic conditions, this appendix uses MIT’s Living Wage Calculator (2024 data) for Newark, NJ, as a benchmark:

Household Type	Living Wage (Hourly)	Notes
Single Adult (no children)	\$18.29	Baseline cost of living with modest housing & food
Single Adult + 1 child	\$35.67	Reflects childcare, healthcare, and transportation costs
Two Adults (1 working) + 1 child	\$34.98	Reflects one income earner with dependent
Two Adults (both working) + 1 child	\$21.77 (per adult)	Shared income burden

GH+ Position Targeting:

- **Tier 1:** Aligned with single adult baseline at \$18/hr
- **Tier 2–3:** Progressively aligned with regional goals toward \$22–24/hr for long-term sustainability

Note: Wage data sourced from the MIT Living Wage Calculator for Essex County (2024), adjusted slightly for rounding.

Appendix B: Occupational Health Considerations for Gallery Hosts

Gallery Hosts often work long hours standing, navigating high-sensory environments, and interacting with hundreds of guests. GH+ integrates wellness and safety considerations as foundational design features:

Ergonomic Health

- *Standing Strain Relief:* Anti-fatigue mats, ergonomic stools, rotation strategies
- *Footwear Flexibility:* Updated guidelines allowing supportive shoes (need not be part of the standard uniform)

Visual & Auditory Health

- *Low-light Galleries:* Recommendations for contrast sensitivity support and breaks
- *Noise Exposure:* Use of adjustable earplugs for event coverage, AV testing

Mental & Emotional Well-being

- *Repetitive Shift Burnout:* Host reflection time and cross-training as cognitive variation
- *Guest Interactions:* Peer support for handling sensitive or confrontational moments
- *Mindfulness Aids:* Optional quiet rooms or recovery stations for decompressing

These considerations ensure GH+ is not only aspirational but durable—designed to care for the whole cultural worker, not just their output.

Appendix C: Equipment Recommendations for Gallery Hosts

1. **GPT-Enabled (AI-powered) Interpretation Tools**
 - **Tool:** Portable or desktop-access AI (e.g., ChatGPT) trained on gallery content
 - **Use:** Research, deeper interpretation, and answering visitor questions in real-time
2. **Adjustable Earplugs**
 - **Tool:** Loop Engage/Quiet Plus (or similar)
 - **Use:** Reduce overstimulation during loud events while maintaining conversational clarity
3. **Self-Defense & Physical Training**
 - **Tool:** Optional training modules or partnerships (e.g., local martial arts studios)
 - **Use:** Build confidence, safety awareness, and professional boundaries during high-stakes guest encounters
4. **Ergonomic and Support Equipment**
 - **Anti-Fatigue Mats:** Cushioned floor mats that reduce pressure on joints and

muscles caused by prolonged standing. They promote better circulation and reduce back, leg, and foot fatigue. Recommended placement at stationary gallery posts.

- **High Stools:** Ergonomic stools with footrests and slight mobility to allow hosts to rest without fully sitting or disengaging. Metrics for evaluation include reduction in reported musculoskeletal discomfort, compliance with use during long shifts, and increased ability to stay alert and conversational.
- **Uniform Options (Project Fit):** Project Fit is a co-designed uniform initiative that invites gallery hosts to directly shape what they wear. Through structured workshops and collaborative design feedback sessions, interested staff can propose styles, fabrics, fits, and cultural influences that resonate with their identities—whether rooted in streetwear, minimalism, heritage aesthetics, or contemporary fashion. Project Fit encourages creative agency while maintaining professionalism, accessibility, and cohesion. The initiative also offers a unique opportunity to collaborate with the museum’s Marketing and Visitor Experience (VEX) teams. By showcasing host-designed uniforms, Marketing can uplift internal talent and reflect Newark’s vibrant cultural style in public-facing materials, while VEX managers are directly engaged in co-developing functional designs that support staff comfort and visitor perception. This interdepartmental connection reinforces the host’s role as both ambassador and collaborator. Benefits include stronger team morale, increased comfort and pride in daily presentation, and reduced friction around dress code expectations.

These investments enhance the day-to-day wellness and agency of gallery staff and reflect a forward-thinking institutional commitment to holistic care.

Appendix D: Pilot Program Budget Outline (Estimated)

This budget outlines estimated costs for the GH+ Pilot Program (Summer–Fall 2025), assuming 5 participants over approximately 16 weeks. Figures are illustrative and require refinement with Finance and relevant departments.

Category	Estimated Cost	Notes
Personnel (Pilot Stipend/Wage Adj.)	\$2,500 - \$3,000	Covers compensation for 1-2 hrs/wk GH+ time per participant (e.g., via stipend or Tier 1 wage rate).
Equipment & Training (Pilot Group)	\$400 - \$600	Includes items like adjustable earplugs, potential contribution to optional self-

		defense training.
Ergonomic Equipment (Potential Need)	<i>(Noted)</i>	Costs for additional anti-fatigue mats or high stools depend on current inventory and placement needs.
Administrative/Mentor Time	<i>(In-Kind)</i>	Assumes time is absorbed by existing staff roles during pilot phase. May require allocation if scaled.
Contingency (Approx. 10%)	\$300 - \$400	For unforeseen expenses.
TOTAL ESTIMATED PILOT COST	\$3,200 - \$4,000	To be funded via [Specify Potential Source: e.g., Operating Budget, Specific Grant, DEIA Fund]

Appendix E: Risk Assessment and Mitigation Strategies

Potential Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation Strategies
Scheduling Conflicts / Finding GH+ Time	Medium	Medium	Identify dedicated GH+ time slots during low-traffic periods; ensure clear communication & flexibility between VEX managers, hosts, and mentors.
Insufficient Mentor Availability/Bandwidth	Medium	High	Clearly define manageable scope for GH+ tasks; identify backup mentors; provide institutional recognition/support for mentor participation.
Budget Constraints for Scaling Program	High	High	Use pilot data to demonstrate ROI (retention,

			engagement); actively seek external grant funding (Phase 3); propose phased rollout aligned with budget cycles.
Participant Attrition/Lack of Interest	Low	Medium	Ensure participation is voluntary; clearly communicate benefits & expectations; provide meaningful tasks; implement regular check-ins & feedback loops.
Resistance from Departments	Low-Medium	Medium	Secure executive sponsorship; highlight benefits for departments (support, fresh perspectives); start with enthusiastic mentor partners; clear MOUs.